sugar mill), and was often seen roaming around Baramati on a Rajdoot motorcycle with his associates. He was also attracted to the Shetkari Sanghatana led by farmer leader Sharad Joshi for some time. Though he vacated his Lok Sabha seat for his uncle soon after, Ajit, who is married to Sunetra, the sister of former minister Dr Padamsinh Patil from Osmanabad, was elected from the Baramati assembly constituency the same year, a seat he has not relinquished till date.

UNCLE VS NEPHEW

The two Pawars are a study in contrast. Pawar Sr is seen as a shrewd leader, a consummate politician who has friends across the spectrum. Ajit is perceived as brash and condescending, with few close friends and a knack for getting into controversies with his crass comments (like in 2013 when he asked if he should relieve himself in a dry dam to provide water to protesting farmers).

Their differing styles had also led to friction many a time. Ajit's associates point to the 2004 assembly election, when the NCP secured two seats more than the Congress. Pawar Sr did not press for the chief minister's post even though it was evident Ajit was among the frontrunners in the party for it. In 2010, when the Congress asked then chief minister Ashok Chavan to make way for Prithviraj Chavan after the Adarsh housing society controversy, Ajit upped the ante. Marshalling his forces, Ajit forced his uncle's hand and ensured that he replaced Chhagan Bhujbal as the deputy chief minister. Ironically, Bhujbal is now with Ajit and has taken oath as a minister. Ajit was deputy chief minister till 2014, and some of the controversies he found himself in, like the alleged irrigation projects scam, are attributed to his blow-hot, blow-cold ties with other senior NCP leaders.

Yet, Ajit was seen as his uncle's political heir until cousin Supriya joined politics and became a Rajya Sabha MP in 2006. She has been the Lok Sabha MP from Baramati since 2009. The uneasiness over Sule's role was coupled with the entry of nephew Rohit into active politics. Rohit, grandson of the late Dinkarrao, was elected to the Pune zilla parishad in 2017. Two years later, he won against the odds in the Karjat-Jamkhed assembly segment in Ahmednagar after a campaign that Pawar Sr personally monitored. This was just months after Ajit's elder son Parth lost from the Maval Lok Sabha seat in the 2019 general election amid allegations that a section of the NCP in the Pimpri-Chinchwad region had not campaigned for him.

Put together, the events reportedly complicated matters within the family. Parth's candidature led to his granduncle choosing to opt out of a Lok Sabha contest from Madha as two members of the family were already in the fray. Eventually, the BJP won Madha, which Pawar had represented in the Lok Sabha from 2009-14. "It must be understood that the Pawars are a joint yet *vibhakta* (divided) family," an associate of the Pawars noted after Ajit's revolt. However, despite the underlying tensions, the Pawars (the extended family has around hundred members) continued to maintain a happy façade, getting together in Baramati every Diwali.

ONE OF PAWAR'S EX-AIDES CLAIMS IT'S ALL A CHARADE TO KEEP AJIT OUT OF JAIL, THAT THE "PAWARS CAN NEVER SPLIT". THE TRUTH WILL OUT WHEN IT'S CONTEST TIME FOR THE BARAMATI LS SEAT NEXT YEAR

THE FINAL PUSH

A senior leader of the Shiv Sena (Uddhav Balasaheb Thackeray) says Ajit's life-long ambition of becoming Maharashtra CM had been eating away at him of late. This, coupled with reports that he was under the Enforcement Directorate (ED) lens, may have forced his hand, he adds. In fact, the spectre of the ED must have affected the revolt decision of at least half a dozen top leaders in the Ajit camp. Meanwhile, ex-CM and Congress leader Prithviraj Chavan has publicly alleged that the BJP is likely to sack Chief Minister Eknath Shinde of the Shiv Sena splinter faction with Ajit taking the top job. After the split in the NCP, Ajit too has been saying (half in jest) that he has held the post of deputy CM a record five times, and it was high time he transitioned to the top post.

The nephew was also said to be upset at being made the fall guy in his short-lived dalliance with the BJP in 2019, which saw him take oath as Devendra Fadnavis's deputy for 72 hours. This was followed by the formation of the Maharashtra Vikas Aghadi government under Uddhav Thackeray, in which Ajit was again deputy CM. That regime was toppled by Shinde's June 2022 revolt, after which Ajit became leader of the opposition.

In his memoirs released in May, Pawar Sr had denied knowledge of any pact between Ajit and the BJP in 2019. However, he has now admitted he was on board but claims this was a "googly" that eventually stumped Fadnavis and exposed the BJP's greed for power. The power struggle between uncle and nephew over the realignment of the NCP towards the BJP saw Pawar Sr stepping down as party chief in May, only to reverse the decision after the party closed ranks with him.

While many were taken aback with Ajit joining the BJP alliance (they had been at each other's throats recently), the family associate quoted earlier points to how the nephew has a strong Sangh Parivar connection on his mother's side. His cousin Chandrashekhar Kadam is an ex-BJP MLA from Rahuri in Ahmednagar, while another cousin, Jagdish, is associated with Sangh Parivar-controlled institutions like the Janata Sahakari Bank and was close to the late historian B.M. 'Babasaheb'